

including Alan Turing, who helped the Allied Forces defeat the Nazis during the second world war by cracking the German *Enigma* code. Symbolically, it is hoped that the summit will result in a strong collaboration between nations aiming to build effective guardrails for the proper use of AI. However, some cynics remind us that the code-breakers team later evolved into UK's most powerful intelligence agency, which, in cahoots with the US, spied on the rest of the world!

Regulations are rife, yet innovation thrives

The idea behind these regulatory efforts is not to dampen the growth of AI—because everyone realises that AI can play a very constructive role in this world. As a simple example, take AI4Bharat, a government-backed initiative at IIT Madras, which develops open source datasets, tools, models, and applications for Indian languages. Microsoft Jugalbandi is a generative AI chatbot for government assistance, powered by AI4Bharat. Local users can ask the chatbot a question in their own language—either voice or text—and get a response in the same language. The chatbot retrieves relevant content, usually in English, and translates it into the local language for the user. The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) is working with AI4Bharat to facilitate voice-based merchant payments and peer-to-peer transactions in local Indian languages. This one example is enough to show the role of AI in bridging the digital divide. But there is more if you wish to know.

Karya, a Bengaluru-based startup founded by Stanford-alumnus Manu Chopra, focuses on sourcing, annotating, and labelling non-English data, with high accuracy. The 2021 startup, which predates the ChatGPT buzz, promises its clients high-quality local-language content, eliminating bias, discrimination, and misinformation at the data level.

AI services trained using only English content often tend to have an improper view of other cultures. In a media story, Stanford University professor Mehran Sahami explained that it is critical to have a broad representation of training data, including non-English data, so AI systems do not perpetuate harmful stereotypes, produce hate speech, or yield misinformation. Karya attempts to bridge this gap by collecting content in a wide range of Indian languages. The startup achieves this by employing workers, especially women, from rural areas. Their app allows workers to enter content even without Internet access and provides voice support for those with limited literacy. Supported by grants, Karya pays the workers nearly 20 times the prevailing market rate, to ensure they maintain a high quality of work. According to a news report, over 32,000 crowdsourced workers have logged into the app in India, completing 40 million digital tasks, including image recognition, contour alignments, video annotation, and speech annotation. Karya is now a sought-after partner for tech giants like Microsoft and Google, who aim to ultra-localise AI.

On the tech front, people are betting on quantum computing to give AI an unprecedented thrust. With that kind of computing power, AI can help us understand several natural phenomena and find ways to sort out problems ranging from poverty to global warming.

And then, there is xAI, Elon Musk's 'truth-seeking' AI model. Released to a select audience in November this year, it is touted to be a serious competition for OpenAI's ChatGPT, Google's Bard, and Anthropic's Claude. In another interesting marketing spin, we see AI being positioned as a coworker or collaborator, assuaging the job-stealer image it has acquired. Recently released Microsoft Copilot hopes to be your 'everyday AI companion,' taking mundane tasks off users' minds, reducing their stress, and helping them to collaborate and

work better. Microsoft thinks Copilot subscriptions could rake in more than \$10 billion per year by 2026.

From online retail, quick-service restaurants and social media platforms to financial institutions, innumerable organisations seem to be introducing AI-driven features in their products and platforms. In a media report, Shopify's Chief Financial Officer Jeff Hoffmeister remarked that the company's AI tools are like a 'superpower' for sellers. Google has also been talking about their latest AI features helping small businesses and merchants create an impact this holiday season. Google's AI-powered Product Studio lets merchants and advertisers create new product imagery for free, simply by typing in a prompt of the image they want to use. Airbnb also seems to be betting big on AI. If rumours are to be believed, Instagram is working on a trailblazing feature that lets users create personalised AI chatbots that can engage in conversations, answer questions, and offer support.

On the usage front, people continue to find interesting uses for AI, even as many industry leaders have barred their employees from using it for writing code and other content. A South Indian movie maker, for example, used AI to create a younger version of the lead actor, for the flashback scenes.

The more AI is used, the more we hear of lawsuits being filed against AI companies—concerning misinformation, defamation, intellectual property rights, and more. Recently, Scarlett Johansson (Black Widow in the Avengers movies) filed a case against Lisa AI, for using her face and voice in an AI-generated advertisement, without her permission. Tom Hanks also alerted his fans of a video promoting a dental plan that used an AI version of him, without his permission. According to a report in *The Guardian*, comedian Sarah Silverman has also sued OpenAI and Meta for copyright infringement.